Introduction

MEMORIAL ADDRESS

delivered by Max von Laue
in the Albani Church in Göttingen
on October 7, 1947

My Fellow Mourners:

We stand at the bier of a man who lived to be almost four-score-and-ten. Ninety years are a long life, and these particular ninety years were extraordinarily rich in experiences. Max Planck would remember, even in his old age, the sight of Prussian and Austrian troops marching into his native town of Kiel. The birth and meteoric ascent of the German Empire occurred during his lifetime, and so did its total eclipse and ghastly disaster. These events had a most profound effect on Planck in his person, too. His eldest son, Karl, died in action at Verdun in 1916. In the Second World War, his house went up in flames during an air raid. His library, collected throughout a whole long lifetime, disappeared, no one knows where, and the most terrible blow of all fell when his second son, Erwin, lost his life in the rule of terror in January, 1945. While on a lecture tour, Max Planck, himself, was an eye-witness of the destruction of Kassel, and was buried in an air raid shelter for several hours. In the middle of May, 1945, the Americans sent a car to his estate of Rogätz on the Elbe, then a theatre of war, to take him to Göttingen. Now we are taking him to his final resting-place.

In the field of science, too, Planck's lifetime was an epoch of deep-reaching changes. The physical science of our days shows an aspect totally different from that of 1875, when Planck began to devote himself to it—and Max Planck is entitled to the lion's share in the credit for these changes. And what a wondrous story his life was! Just think—A boy of seventeen, just graduated from high school, he decided to take up a science which even its most authoritative representative whom he could consult, described as one of mighty meager prospects. As a student, he chose a certain branch of this science, for which even its neighbor sciences had but little regard—and even within this particular branch a highly specialized field, in which literally nobody at all had any interest whatever. His first scientific papers were not read even by Helmholtz, Kirchhoff and Clausius, the very men who would have found it easiest to appreciate them. Yet, he continued on his way, obeying an inner call, until he came face to face with a problem which many